for leadership, is a dud: earnest, but lacking in energy, ideas, strategy, and, crucially, the ability to connect with party workers and voters.'

Is Rahul really a 'dud'? I hardly know him at all to answer that with any certitude, but what I will say is that he has singularly failed to show any quality that marks him out as a leader who can lift a struggling party. He is probably the first member of the Nehru–Gandhi family who doesn't even command the respect of his own party men. At a lunch, an agitated senior Congress leader told me, 'We need a change in leadership, Rahul must go!' I asked him if he had any replacement in mind. He admitted there was no one he could single out right away. The only option being occasionally mentioned is Priyanka, who remains insistent that she is not entering formal politics.

To that extent, the Gandhi family remains both an asset and a liability—it holds the party together in the absence of any alternative leadership, but it also terribly retards the party's growth by creating a political culture that thrives on a nauseating sycophancy and an unwillingness to empower its regional leaders. Dynasty alone will not sustain the Congress—it needs to throw up a merit-driven, mass-based leadership that can usher in new ideas and energies.

Over the years, the 'umbrella' party that could co-opt and accommodate conflicting interest groups has badly atrophied, to the point where decay has now set in. UP and Bihar are a good example—in the two big states of the Hindi heartland, the Congress has fossilized. 'You can identify a Congressman by his age. The older they are, the more likely they are to have been Congress supporters at some stage,' is how a UP leader explained the predicament.

So, how will this ageing party, devoid of a robust organization, really combat a cadre-based party like the BJP? 'Nothing is permanent in politics, things will change in five years. Who would have thought in 2009 that we would lose the 2014 elections so badly?' is what one Congress MP told me. If this attitude lulls the Congress into complacency, then Modi could provide them with another wakeup call. Modi is not Morarji Desai, the Janata Party prime minister who was unable to hold a disparate flock